SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #55 · RELIGIOUS UPBRINGING & TRAINING

“Enjoying life is worldly or sinful.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A strict religious upbringing that frowned on fun, laughter, music, or celebration. Hearing that pleasure leads to sin. Feeling guilty when relaxing or having a good time. Seeing Christianity as mostly about rules and sacrifice. Confusing worldliness with enjoyment of God’s good gifts.

What Scripture teaches

God richly provides everything for us to enjoy. Ecclesiastes says there is nothing better than to rejoice, eat, drink, and find satisfaction in our work, because it is God’s gift. Jesus came that we might have life in all its fullness, and in God’s presence there is joy and eternal pleasure. Worldliness is loving the things of the world more than God, not enjoying God’s gifts with thanks.

> *“Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy”* **(1 Timothy 6:17)**.

Also see

> “I know that there is nothing better for them than to rejoice and do good while they live, and also that every man should eat and drink and find satisfaction in all his labor—this is the gift of God” **(Ecclesiastes 3:12–13)**.

> “The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. I have come that they may have life, and have it in all its fullness” **(John 10:10)**.

> “You have made known to me the path of life; You will fill me with joy in Your presence, with eternal pleasures at Your right hand” **(Psalm 16:11)**.

> “Then Nehemiah told them, ‘Go and eat what is rich, drink what is sweet, and send out portions to those who have nothing prepared, since today is holy to our Lord. Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.’” **(Nehemiah 8:10)**.

Common self-statements

- Having fun is unspiritual.
- If I enjoy something, I should feel guilty.
- Real Christians are serious all the time.
- Pleasure always leads to sin.
- God wants me to be miserable to stay holy.
- Laughing and celebrating are worldly.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing every pleasure is either sinful or spiritual.
- **Overgeneralization:** Treating all enjoyment as worldliness.
- **Should statements:** “I should not enjoy life too much.”
- **Mental filter:** Overlooking Scripture’s celebration of joy, feasts, and gifts.

Challenging questions

- What does 1 Timothy 6:17 say God provides things for?
- Did Jesus attend celebrations and feasts?
- What is the difference between enjoying a gift and worshiping it?
- Who taught me that enjoyment is sinful?
- Does misery make me more like Christ?
- What gifts has God given me to enjoy?
- How could I enjoy life in a way that honors God?

Truth summary

> Enjoying life is not worldly or sinful. God richly provides everything for me to enjoy. Jesus came to give me life in all its fullness. I can enjoy God's good gifts with thanksgiving, without making them my god. The joy of the LORD is my strength.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Joy
- Thankful
- Blessings
- Worldly
- Praise Him

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Enjoying life is worldly or sinful"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Enjoying life is worldly or sinful." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does God provide things for?
- ☐ Did Jesus attend celebrations?
- ☐ Enjoying a gift or worshiping it: which is this?
- ☐ Who taught me enjoyment is sinful?
- ☐ Does misery make me more like Christ?
- ☐ What gifts has God given me to enjoy?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God richly provides all things for me to enjoy.
- ☐ Jesus came to give me life in all its fullness.
- ☐ I can enjoy God's gifts with thanksgiving.
- ☐ The joy of the LORD is my strength.
- ☐ In God's presence there is fullness of joy.
- ☐ Enjoyment is not the same as worldliness.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **1 Timothy 6:17**
  "Instruct those who are rich in the present age not to be conceited and not to put their hope in the uncertainty of wealth, but in God, who richly provides all things for us to enjoy."
- [ ] **Ecclesiastes 3:12–13**
  "I know that there is nothing better for them than to rejoice and do good while they live, and also that every man should eat and drink and find satisfaction in all his labor—this is the gift of God."
- [ ] **John 10:10**
  "The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. I have come that they may have life, and have it in all its fullness."
- [ ] **Psalm 16:11**
  "You have made known to me the path of life; You will fill me with joy in Your presence, with eternal pleasures at Your right hand."
- [ ] **Nehemiah 8:10**
  "Then Nehemiah told them, 'Go and eat what is rich, drink what is sweet, and send out portions to those who have nothing prepared, since today is holy to our Lord. Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

✦ ✦ ✦

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Enjoyment log:** Each day, write one good gift I enjoyed and a one-line thank-you to God.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 16:11 becomes: "You have made known to **Sarah** the path of life; You will fill **her** with joy in Your presence, with eternal pleasures at Your right hand."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Joy" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Plan one enjoyable activity this week,** such as a meal with friends, music, or time outdoors, and thank God during it.
- ☐ **Read John 2:1–11,** and write what Jesus' first miracle says about celebration.
- ☐ **Notice guilt when you relax,** and answer it with 1 Timothy 6:17.
- ☐ **Laugh with someone today** and thank God for the gift of humor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Enjoying life is worldly or sinful": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One gift I enjoyed with thanks
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Enjoying life is worldly or sinful.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for the many good gifts You give me to enjoy. Help me reject the lie that enjoying life is worldly or sinful. Teach me to receive Your gifts with thanksgiving, to keep You first, and to know that the joy of the LORD is my strength. In Jesus' name, Amen.

✦ ✦ ✦

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.